

10 Prince of Persia Years: 1989-2010

In terms of artistic excellence, it stood head and shoulders above all other platformers in its time, and its simplistic elegance can still hold its own against today's games. POP is gaming filtered down to its essence: kill the bad guy, save the world, get the girl.



7 Death Rally Year: 1996

Death Rally is the only one of its kind: a racing game with soul. It treats racing not as mere competition, but a way of life. Of particular note are the quotes that appear at the bottom of the screen: "All bitter regrets are in the past; blurred sweet streetlights speeding past, fast". Cheesy? Yes. Suiting the game's style? Hell, yes.



5 Grim Fandango Year: 1998

Classical adventure gaming is all about telling a story, and no game tells a story better than Grim Fandango. Be it the graphics that utilised Mexican and noir themes, this title stands out as one of the finest productions in the history of gaming.



2 Super Mario Bros. Years: 1985-2010

The fun, accessible, and addictive gameplay of the SMB series has earned it this rank. Truly the biggest franchise of past, present, and future, this series has literally crushed mascots of other platforms such as SEGA's Sonic the Hedgehog and PlayStation's Crash Bandicoot. The only reason this isn't #1 is because of a tiny, insignificant little thing called... (see #1)



9 Call of Duty Years: 2003-2010

With each release, the COD franchise has gone from strength to strength, and currently holds the record of the largest-selling FPS. The combination of arcade action with realistic weapons, together with tightly-scripted levels that provide a cinematic feel to the action has been maintained across its iterations.



6 Fallout Years: 1997-2010

When it comes to post-apocalyptic sci-fi, nothing can touch Fallout with a sharpened spear. Its alternate-reality mix of 1950s vacuum tube technology with high-powered Gauss Rifles has a special appeal all its own. Another unforgettable aspect is its liberal dose of dark humour. Regardless of how hopeless the future of the world might seem, there's always someone around to make a wisecrack about it.



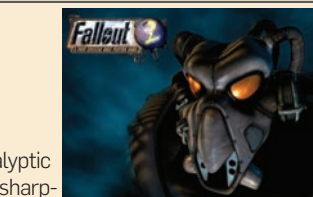
4 Road Rash Years: 1991-2003

Road Rash is the most fun motorcycle racing game ever made, and practically everyone who owns a PC has enjoyed it, including 60-year-old grandmas — and we say this from personal experience. An elderly lady once wanted to play Road Rash at the SKOAR! 2008 expo because her grandkids would not let her play at home.



8 Aliens Versus Predator Years: 1993-2010

AVP is actually three games in one — an excellent horror FPS (Marine), a hi-tech stealth FPS (Predator), and the Alien campaign that has no parallel in any other franchise. You can't beat playing from the viewpoint of the two coolest villains in Sci-Fi lore.



3 God of War Years: 2005-2010

The GOW franchise has continually churned out one superlative experience after another. Each new title pushes the boundaries of what the game's console is capable of, and each release continues to make the act of mass destruction extremely fun. The GOW series continues to symbolize the epitome of polish and smoothness in gameplay, and there seems to be no stopping this juggernaut.



Disclaimer:

This lineup isn't called anything predictable like "25 Best Games Ever" because we've assumed that better games will continue to be made in the future. That is, unless you believe we're all going to die in December 2012. Like all "Best Of" lists, this is a highly subjective ranking that might not go down well with a section of the readership (read: rabid fanboys). Kindly excuse.

All the titles in this arrangement are primarily single-player experiences, since storytelling is key to making a great game. In cases where a franchise has produced many excellent titles, we've gone with including the entire series instead of individual games. Finally, this manifest tends to lean towards games published on PCs rather than consoles.

1 Carmageddon

Years: 1997-2000

Carmageddon is not about racing, but something else entirely — cutting loose. It's pure, unadulterated evil; a no-holds-barred, violent smashfest of the highest order that boasts true freedom to win the race by your preferred means: cross all checkpoints, wreck all other opponents, or kill all pedestrians.

If most games are about the triumph of good over evil, Carmageddon is the antithesis. In Carpoolcypse Now!, the last level takes place in a nuclear reactor, and your objective is to hit the huge button that will destroy the reactor and cause the world's destruction. In a world where everyone tries to be politically correct, this comes as a breath of fresh air.

The final word on this game comes from a friend who says, "After I play, I make it a point to relax for 15 minutes before I go out, because I'm afraid I might drive the same way in the real world". Now that's immersion.

